

BUDGET LAPTOPS

Again, a category that's really, really popular, and confusing because of the many options

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There are plenty of things to consider when it comes to buying a laptop this festival season, especially when shopping on a tight budget. That's where we come in.

IT'S A BUDGET LAPTOP!

Let's get one thing clear. Between ₹25k to ₹35k, you're not going to get yourself a performance beast. You will have to compromise on build quality, you won't get Alienware-like performance, or get the latest hardware configurations, or even connectivity features for that matter. Don't worry, you'll still get a very good computing machine.

BUYING OLDER GENERATION GEMS?

Laptops go through an annual cycle of hardware refresh. Stocks of last year's mid-ranged laptops which were originally sold at the ₹50k mark may be available at huge discounts, as OEMs try to clear their inventory. When this happens, keep your eyes open. You may just get your hands on an Intel Core i5 laptop with a 1GB discrete graphics at a throwaway price. As long as you're buying it from an authorized seller and it's a boxed piece with a warranty card, you can go ahead and buy these gems.

PAY ATTENTION TO

Keyboard and trackpad: More than the hardware features, pay attention to subjective aspects of a laptop that also distinguish one from another. Look for keyboards that don't short-change the sizes of important keys such as [Shift], [Space], [Alt], [Enter], [Tab], [Ctrl] and the direction keys. Keyboards with a dedicated number pad get two thumbs up. Stay away from trackpads that have a glossy, shiny surface as tracking becomes difficult, and doesn't provide feedback to your fingers.

CPU: Since you are aiming for a basic laptop at an entry-level budget, a dual core processor clocked at 2-GHz, either from Intel or AMD, should be just fine. To save money even further, we've found that AMD processors are generally cheaper than Intel's – but Intel processors are generally better performers.

RAM: Most pre-configured laptops these days offer at least 2GB of RAM – even at the budget price point. Don't buy one with anything less than 2 GB, though more is always a luxury – if you can afford it. Don't fall for loads of RAM with a slow CPU though.

Screen: The larger a laptop's screen, the larger its

weight. Also, screen brightness is the biggest culprit of battery loss, so choose wisely. Instead of just buying a big screen look for a screen size and resolution combo that seems ideal to your eyes. We recommend at least a resolution of 1366x768. You're not going to find a touchscreen at this price point.

GPUs, HDD, Battery: The bigger the better here, but with the budget segment, the choices aren't really overwhelming here, sadly.

REMEMBER

Your laptop won't:

- be an Ultrabook
- a gaming machine
- be exceptionally built
- have all input/output ports or connectivity features
- be worth bragging about

Your laptop may:

- be a Chromebook (<http://dgit.in/1hv68dL>)
- have an older mid-range configuration (Core i5 / 2GB+ RAM / 500GB+ HDD / 1GB discrete GPU)

Your laptop should:

- Sport a 15-inch form factor at least
- be good enough to watch movies, work on an Office suite and other basic apps. 

TOP

★ ULTRABOOKS ★



ACER ASPIRE S7

Intelligent design and hardware choices means that this device performs just as good as it looks.



APPLE MACBOOK AIR 13

Super slim, unibody shell, fantastic build quality, exquisite trackpad and battery life. Simply amazing.



DELL PRECISION M3800

A slim, trim profile, and the performance power of a workstation. Worth every penny.



HP ENVY TOUCH SMART 14-K102TX

A performance-tuned, ultrabook with a multitouch screen, looks, and an connectivity options.



LENOVO YOGA 2

This hybrid has elegant, unique design, and good features and hardware at the price.